

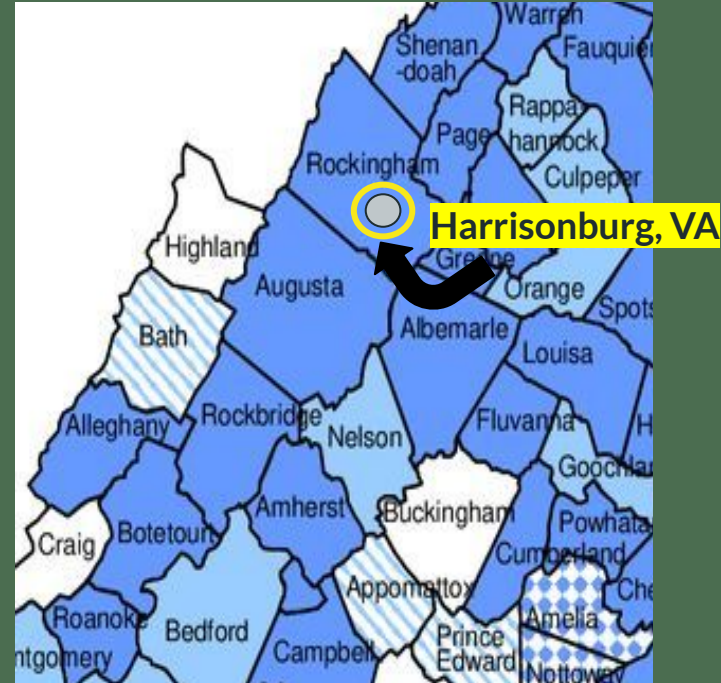


James Madison University Agricultural Partnership

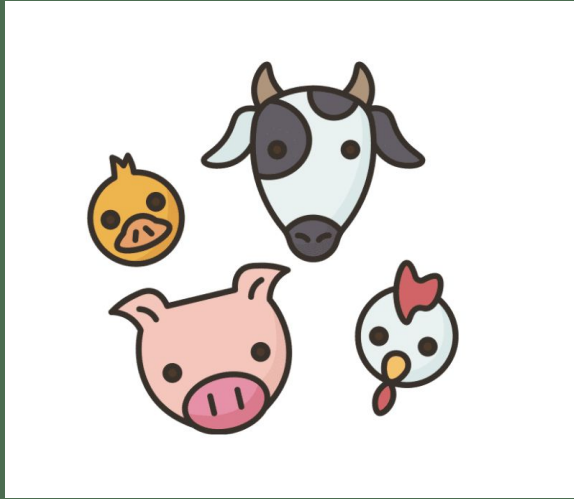
“Who Cares About Small Farms Anyway?”

Why should anyone care about small farms?

1. Begin fostering a generation of young adults who care about their food systems, their wellness, and the benefits of eating locally.
2. Investing in local food systems = investing in people, health, and the planet.
3. Local fresh food can be difficult to access for off-campus students, who make up 68% of the JMU student body.¹
4. Rockingham County is the largest agricultural producing county in VA, totaling 20% of all agricultural sales, and among the top 50 counties in the US.²



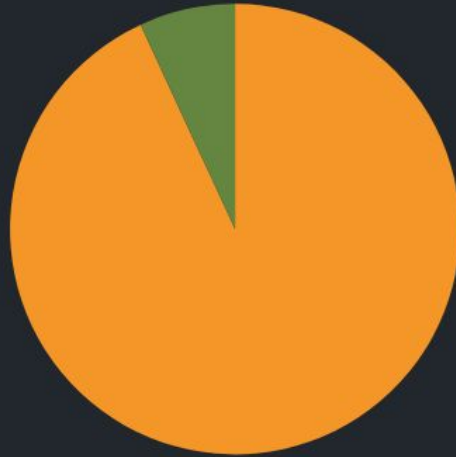
What's the Problem?



Small farms offer fresh, sustainable food, but often lack visibility among college students. Our platform bridges that gap—making it easier for JMU students to access local produce and support regional agriculture.

Is eating fresh and local
produce and meats
something that you
value?

6.9%



Yes

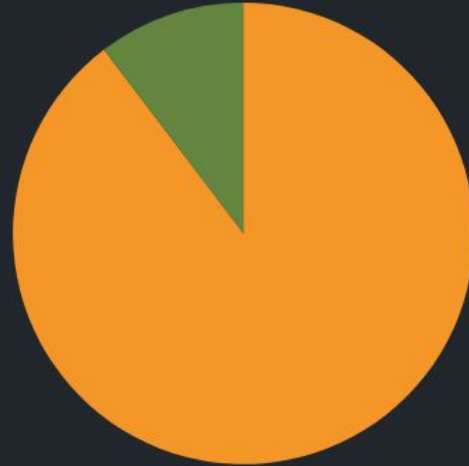
No



93.1%

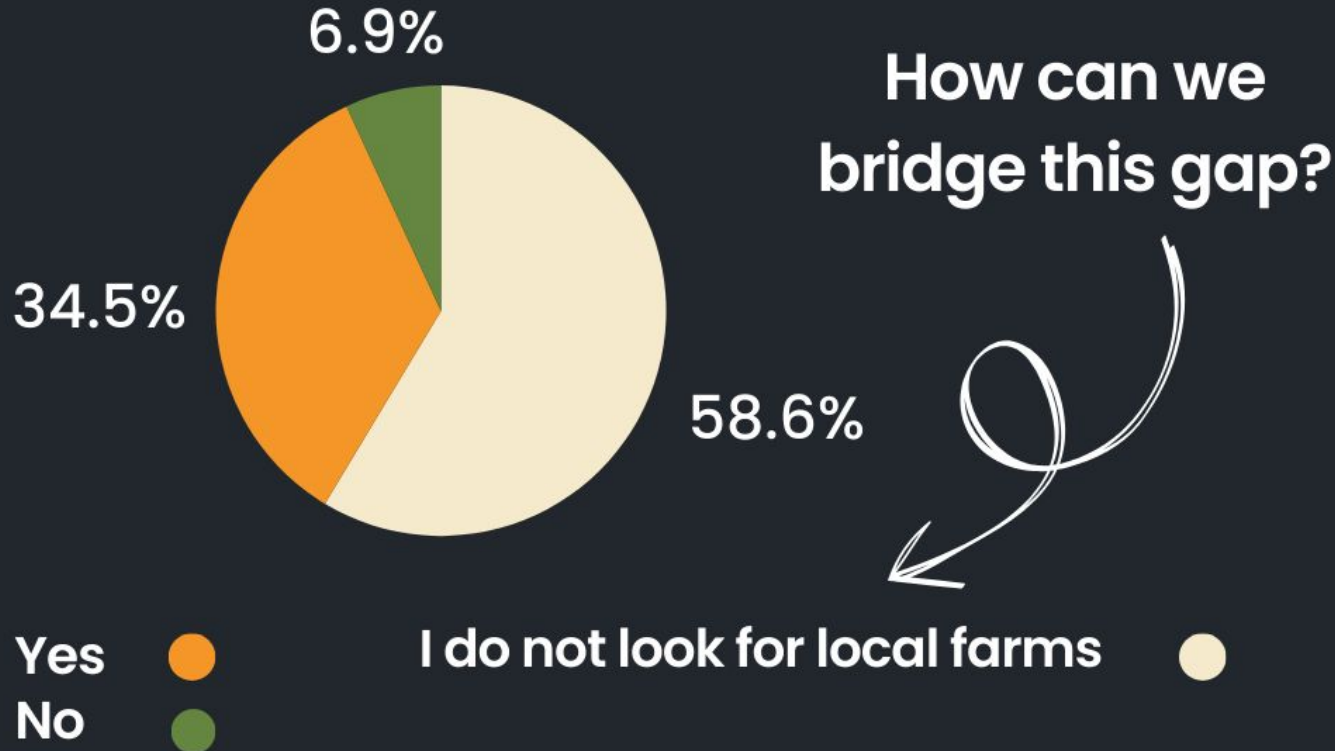
Do you feel that it is
important to know
where your food comes
from?

10.3%



89.7%

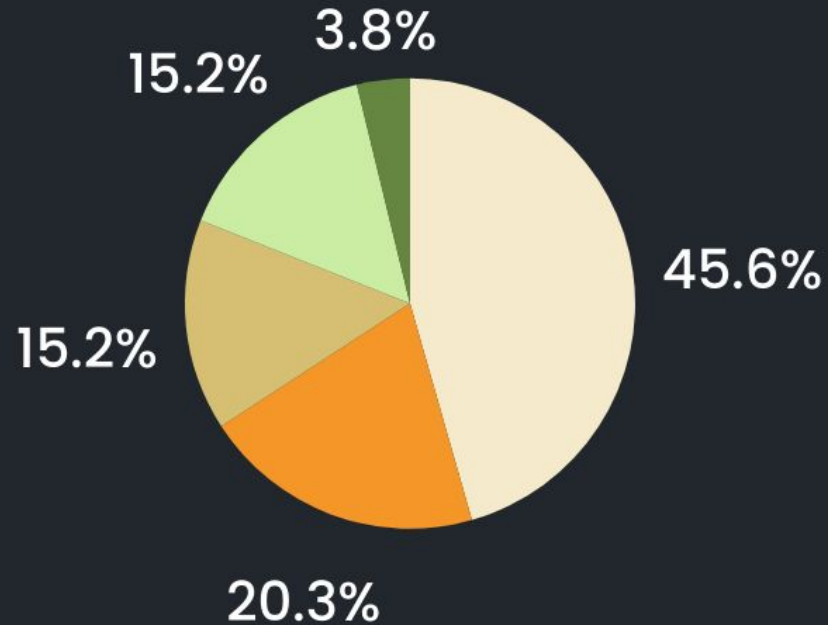
Do you find it difficult to be able to find local farms to get your food from?



Distribution of Conversations (n =100)

Processes of Synthesis:

- Design Thinking
 - Empathy
 - Listening
 - Ideation
 - Prototyping



Students



Local Farmers



Ag.



Gov. Workers



Academic Workers



Workers

Project Vision: The Big Picture

01. Gen Ed Class

- The purpose of this course is to educate students about local and global agriculture and inspire their interest in the field.
- Educate students about local small farms and their impact.
- Provide volunteer opportunities to support small farmers and assist with CSA distribution.

02. CSA

- Community Supported Agriculture, where students pre-pay for weekly boxes of local seasonal produce directly from farmers, building direct relationships and partnerships between local farmers and the JMU community
- Students, faculty, staff, are connected to their food source and are encouraged to eat seasonally
- Off-campus students have easier, convenient access to foods via meal plan, promoting health and wellness

The class and the CSA program will be integrated with each other, informing students on why investing in local agriculture is important, and providing students an opportunity to get involved on campus.

Class: AG 101



- This course introduces students to the fundamentals and basics of agriculture and its significance in shaping our society, environment, and economy.
- The course will include the history of agricultural development, food systems, and sustainability.
- This course would also provide volunteer and internship opportunities for students, which would include helping to distribute CSAs to the students that purchase them.
- This course is designed to connect JMU students with the importance of agriculture and help them discover the essential role local farms play in sustaining our community.

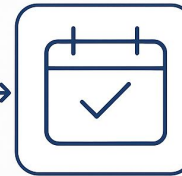
CSA Business Model

- \$30/week for 8 weeks = \$240 per student
- \$10 membership fee for driver support
- Farmers receive 70% of revenue
- JMU program keeps 30% for admin, packing, outreach, marketing, labor, etc.
- Transparent, equitable, community-focused model

Reinforces JMU's commitment to community engagement through environmental, economic, and social responsibility!



Farmer
Partnerships



Subscription
System



Aggregation
and Packing

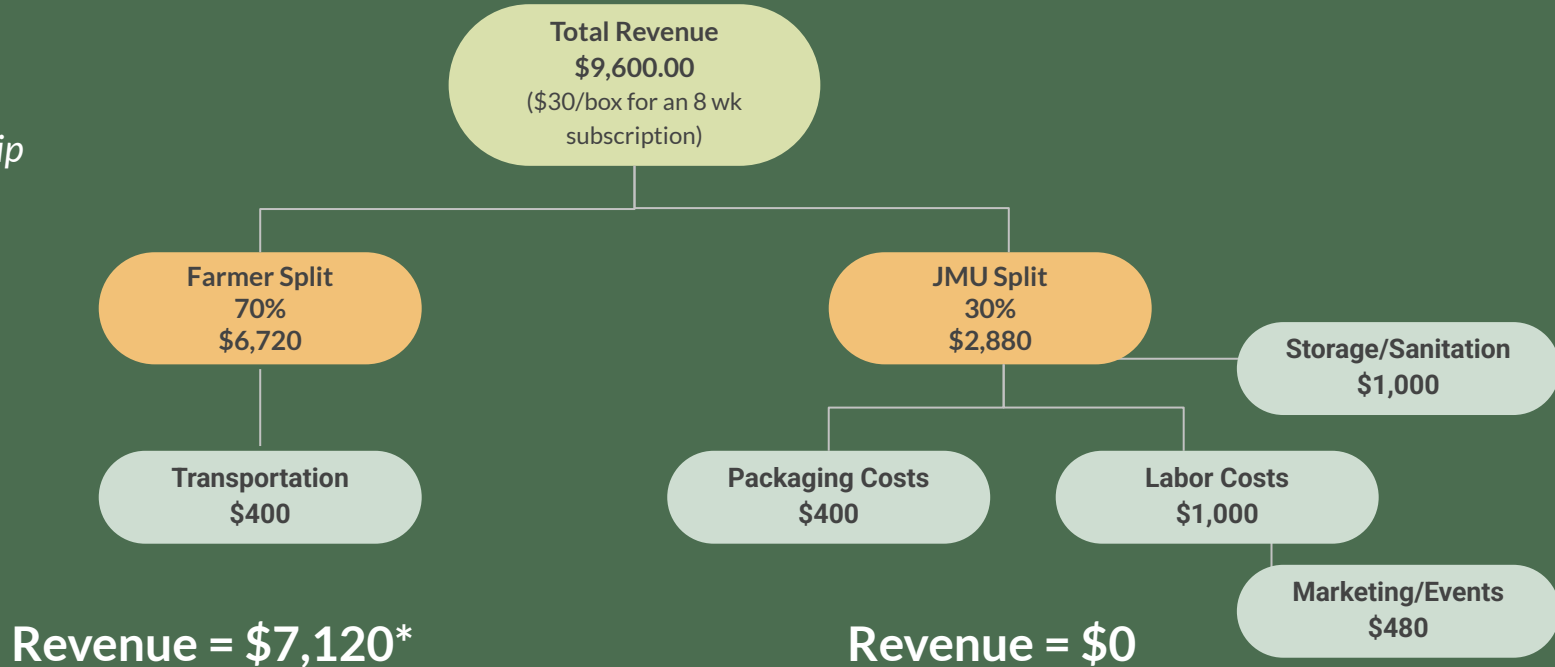


Distribution

Revenue Breakdown Model

Model based on:

- 40 students
- 5 farmers
- \$10 membership fee

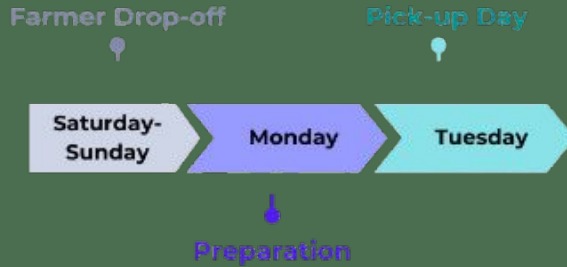


**Dependent on the value and number of items contributed*

**Includes the added membership fee students pay at the beginning of the semester (\$10) that goes directly to farmers for cost of transportation*

CSA Logistics

- Weekly Schedule



- Location

- a. Possible Locations

- UREC, Festival, Pantry, JMU Office of Real Estate

- b. Requirements

- Certifications

- a. Produce Safety Certificate



Partnerships



HomeAgain Farms

"It's good exposure"

Radical Roots Organic Farm

"For us having a large volume will make it worth it for us, so the more the merrier."

Open Door Homestead LLC.

"Yes, we are excited to educate others on reconnecting with their food sources. We do farm to table cooking workshops and this would be a great introduction."

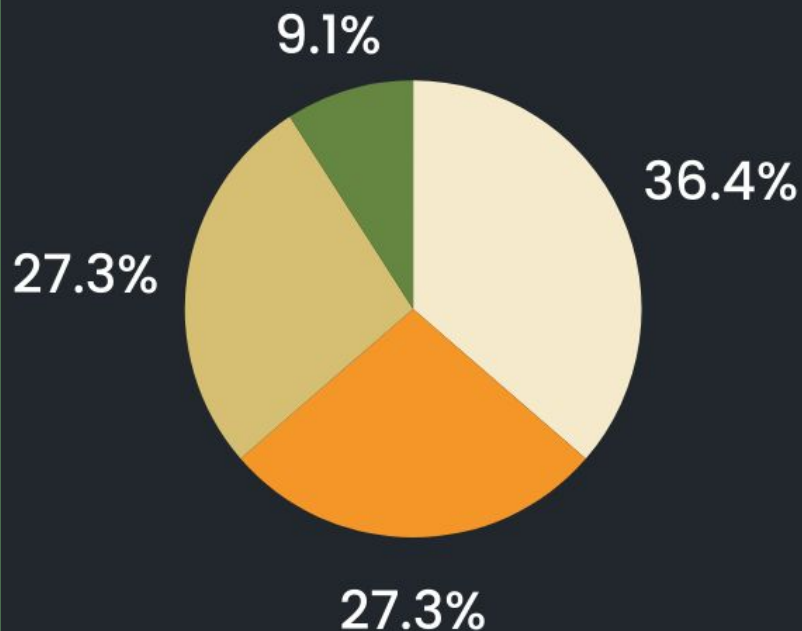
Hobbit Hill Farm

"It sounds like it could be a great idea to support other local farms. I love the idea of building connection between JMU students and local food and local farms!"

Friendly Neighbor Gardens

"Our farm is set up well to offer vegetables in the winter months. Starting small with 40 students and 8 weeks of distribution sounds good for the initial run and working out the logistics of this program. We hope to be involved in this!"

Responses from Local Farms (n =11)



Would you be interested in doing a CSA-like subscription for students as part of their meal plan? (late March/April to mid May, and late August to October)

Yes!



No



Maybe, would want more details



Yes, would want more details



Why are we the best group for this project?

- We've done research, talked to a broad spectrum of people, and built a model that we want to test!
- Our team brings together diverse majors: Kinesiology, Economics, Public Policy, WRTC, Anthropology, and Information Technology
 - This has allowed us to approach the solutions through multiple lenses and skill sets



Future Goals & Next Steps

1

Finalize partnerships through building trust and credibility with local farmers and campus departments

2

Market AG 101 and the CSA program to the JMU community, educating others and promoting local agriculture

3

Provide volunteer and internship opportunities through the AG 101 Gen Ed class which would include volunteering with the CSA Program

4

Integrate with JMU academic departments (sustainability, nutrition, business) and the AG 101 Gen Ed

5

Continue to research logistics and policies such as storage and distribution location, labor, packaging/food safety policies, etc.

6

Launch pilot CSA and expand to serve 100+ students per semester and become a model CSA program for other universities to implement!





Thank you!

Dukes Roots (CSA) Program Proposal



Ag 101 Course Proposal

